

reduced the amount of food available. Then communist governments used food shortages as a weapon against their internal enemies.

Obviously, the first protection against famine is wealth. There is almost always food available at some price. Generally, but not always, it goes to the highest bidder. So having some money is in itself a measure of safety. Always has been.

But people with wealth can also be popular scapegoats when times get tough. The easy money policies of the Fed during the last two decades have made America's rich richer than ever, while the incomes and wealth of 99 percent of the population have barely risen at all. If food supplies were short, it wouldn't be at all surprising if the mobs turned against "the rich," intentionally withholding food from them.

Hunger was largely responsible for the French Revolution. Mobs gathered in front the Tuileries Palace, protesting the high cost of food. Inflation and bad weather had driven up the price of a loaf of bread to almost an entire day's wages by an ordinary laborer.

Marie Antoinette, wife of Louis XVI, is said to have asked:

"What are they complaining about?"

"They have no bread," came the answer.

"Well, let them eat cake," was her witty, but ultimately fatal, reply.

She lost her head in the Revolution. So did thousands of others.

Mobs need scapegoats. And hungry mobs are not particularly careful about whom they choose.

"That's one of the big differences between the French and British aristocracy," our family matriarch, Elizabeth, enlightened us:

The French aristocrats were encouraged to move to Versailles and take part in the life of the central government. They may have owned vast estates in Normandy or Aquitaine. But the real action—social, as well as political—took place in and near Paris. So they lost contact with their sources of power, their *terres*, their family strongholds. When the revolution came, they had no local support. Their peasants turned against them. Many lost their estates and their heads.

The English aristocracy, on the other hand, tended to be jealous of its local rights and privileges and stuck close to its land. They were never